Top 3 Software Ideas for Local Businesses

Ludhiana · for a full-stack student developer with 10–12 hours a week, aiming for a small, steady income

What shaped these picks: owners are comfortable with WhatsApp and UPI but not much more, so each product needs one or two taps for the owner and puts any complexity on the customer side or out of sight. The stationery shop, dairy and canteen are places you visit every week, which gives you direct access to your first users.

1. QR print queue for stationery shops (start here)

Buyer	Photocopy and stationery shops near GNDEC first, then near other colleges and coaching areas in Ludhiana.
Problem	Huge crowds for printouts. Customers log into WhatsApp on the shop PC to download their own files, which is slow and a privacy risk, or send files to the owner's number and depend on a worker who is sometimes absent.
Why first	You have seen this problem yourself and it happens every day. Students would use it right away, and the owner's work actually gets easier.
First version	2–3 weeks. A QR code on the counter opens a web page: the student uploads a file, sets copies and colour, pays by UPI and gets a token number. The shop PC shows a live queue (Socket.IO), the owner clicks Print, and the token shows “Ready”. No app to install, no WhatsApp login on the shop PC.
Price	About ₹500–800 a month, or ₹0.50–1 per job. First month free.
This week	Show the owner a mockup on your phone and ask: *“If students could send prints like this without logging into WhatsApp, would you use it? Would you pay ₹500 a month?”*

2. Dairy milk account with WhatsApp billing

Buyer	The dairy you go to, then other dairies and milk delivery people.
Problem	Month-end arguments over how many litres were taken, register mistakes, and slow payment collection.
Why second	It is a monthly habit the dairy cannot skip. It gets them paid faster and ends arguments, and it is easy for an owner with moderate phone skills because they only record exceptions.
First version	About 2 weeks. A customer list with each customer's usual daily litres. The owner taps only for changes (“+1 L”, “skipped”). At month end a bill with a UPI link goes to each customer on WhatsApp automatically.
Price	About ₹300–500 a month.
This week	Ask the dairy owner how many customers are on monthly accounts and how many argue over the bill each month. Check whether they have tried a milk-diary app.

3. Canteen pre-order and token screen

Buyer	The canteen you use, then other college canteens and nearby dhabas.
Problem	Lunch-hour queues, wrong orders, shouting across the counter, cash handling.
Why third	A daily, visible problem that uses your real-time skills, and you can sell it to the same campus contacts as the print queue.
First version	3–4 weeks. Order and pay through a QR code, an order screen in the kitchen, and the token called when the food is ready.
Price	About ₹800–1,500 a month.
Risk	Getting the owner to change habits is harder here. Start with only the lunch rush.

Backup: private live streams for weddings and events

If one of the three fails when you test it, switch to this. Wedding photographers and studios could offer relatives abroad a private, branded HLS stream with a recording. It uses your rarest skills (HLS/RTMP), and one studio partner could pay more than several shops. You don't yet know anyone in this business, so it ranks lower.

How to sequence it

With 10–12 hours a week, build **one at a time**.

1. This week, talk to all three owners. This takes no code.
2. Build first whichever owner sounds most interested, most likely the print shop.
3. Get one shop using it daily for a month and fix what breaks.
4. Then sell it to the next shop.

Prices and build times are estimates. The owners' answers this week will tell you what they will actually pay.